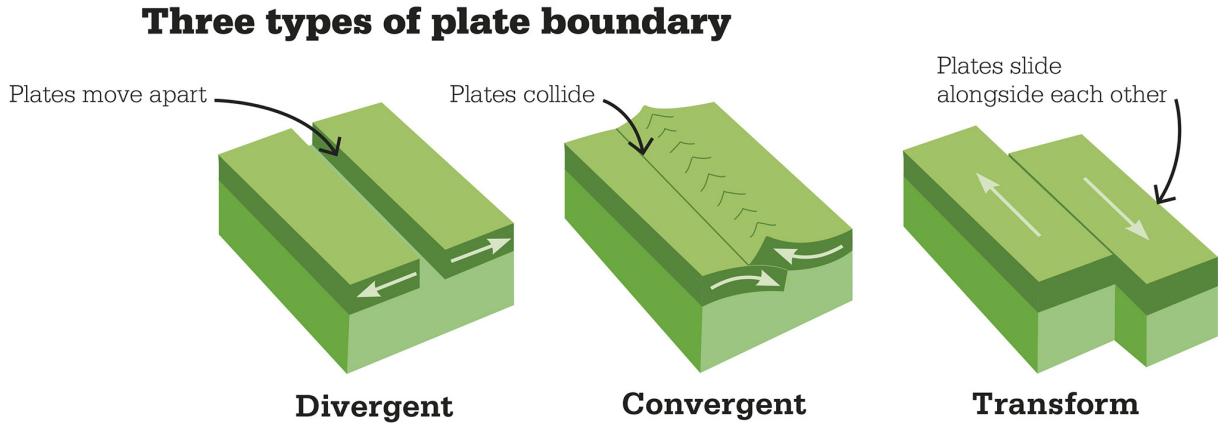
Once Wegener's theory was accepted, the fossil evidence made much better sense. Continental drift has had a profound influence on how species have evolved. For example, if a continent splits apart, the two separated populations of a species can start to evolve in completely different directions. On the other hand, if two continents collide, or a bridge of land forms between them, different species begin to mix and compete, and some may become extinct as a result.



Tectonic plates can move in three different ways, forming different types of boundary. When plates diverge, new oceanic crust is formed. When they converge, new mountains form. When plates slide past each other, the rift is known as a transform fault.

Read accessible description

"The forces which displace continents are the same as those which produce great fold-mountain ranges."

Alfred Wegener